



WITH BRAHMASTRA, "HIS HOMAGE TO THE SPIRIT OF LORD SHIVA", MUKERJI HAS CREATED HIS "OWN UNIVERSE OF CINEMA", ONE HE CALLS THE "ASTRAVERSE"

Nine years have passed since much of young India found itself enamoured with Ayan Mukerji's *Yeh Jawaani Hai Deewani* (*YJHD*). In the interim, Mukerji, much like a James Cameron who has devoted almost all his energies to making the *Avatar* films, has invested nearly a decade of his life to *Brahmastra*, a fantasy action series, part one of which will release on September 9.

"Don't mock me," says Mukerji when he hears the comparison. "What he is achieving—making really good mainstream cinema at a very high quality, cinema that is enjoyable for everyone—is what I want to accomplish in my filmmaking career." The director, 38, is seated in his office surrounded by books, concept art from *Brahmastra* and figurines that show his love for Marvel's Avengers franchise and Harry Potter. A whiteboard lists the deadlines he has to meet. A *trishul* is perched in one corner.

It has been a long, arduous journey for Mukerji. Getting *Brahmastra* started and part one completed has not been easy. As shooting went on for nearly five years, the budget shot up—an estimated Rs 350 crore if the industry grapevine is to be believed. It soon became clear that *Brahmastra* was Mukerji's magnum opus, but given the hype and hoopla around its scale, how did Mukerji keep himself motivated all through? "Sometimes when you do big things in life, you jump in without clearly knowing what you are jumping into. There is no turning back," he says. "I really did feel we are creating something unlike what has been created before and we must see it through."

Much like his characters, be it Sid of *Wake Up Sid!* (2009) or Kabir from *YJHD*, Mukerji embarked on a journey of self-discovery as he went about executing his ambitious project. Unlike his two films, it was heavy on visual effects (VFX) and action. He says, "I didn't have a roadmap, I didn't know what to expect." Self-belief propelled him. "Through all these years, I have believed that this could be my *Star Wars* moment where I will create something which would be an amazing achievement in Indian cinema," he adds. Mukerji spent nearly a year in London acquainting himself with how VFX works. Helping him were the professionals at Double Negative, a renowned multiple Oscar-winning studio, who have worked on "the biggest and most complex" bits of *Brahmastra*, says Mukerji. The remaining work took place at Prime Focus, a stone's throw away from co-producer Karan Johar's Dharma office in Khar, and ReDefine in Andheri. The experience that many Indian VFX artists had acquired while working on Hollywood projects in the past few years has helped *Brahmastra*. Mukerji adds, "At one level, the vision of what we can do had exceeded. I scaled it up as much as I could." Mukerji also met action specialists employed by S.S. Rajamouli, Red Chillies Entertainment and Yash Raj Films. In fact, Rajamouli's *Bahubali* films would end up having a huge influence on the filmmaker. "I feel that in many ways, he's a filmmaking guru now," Mukerji says about the auteur who is helping promote the film in four southern languages. "My vision [for *Brahmas-*